Beyond Raising Awareness

Even ten years later, many still remember the famous *Ice Bucket Challenge* that dominated social media platforms in 2014. Millions joined in to pour buckets of ice water on to their heads, including high-profile figures from Bill Gates to Selena Gomez. Designed to raise awareness for Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis (ALS), a disease that was once underfunded and obscure, the challenge was revolutionary for the ALS Association. The challenge was the fifth most popular Google search of 2014, and the organization raised $115 million in just six weeks (Surowiecki, 2016; Piper, 2019). The fundings helped catalyze research for ALS' environmental causes, treatment and cures (Weintraub, 2024). The challenge undoubtedly achieved the goal of raising awareness. We all remember the internet sensation: laughing at politicians and entrepreneurs break their composed and stoic public persona, watching videos of influencers add their hilarious personal twists to the challenge, perhaps even attempting it yourself with some friends in the backyard. But who remembers what ALS is? Why were we raising money for it? Where did the money go?

Raising awareness can be extremely effective as the first step of an elaborate plan to drive social change. But in a media-dominated world, raising awareness can easily become, and in many ways, is becoming, the entire, one-size-fit-all solution to every social, environmental and political issue we face. This glorification of raising awareness as the key to change brings us to a stage of stagnation where all social movements become performative. This is otherwise known as slacktivism or performative activism which is a form of activism for personal gain rather than to truly promote a cause. This looks like over 17 million people participating in the *ALS Ice Bucket Challenge* in 2014 even though a poll conducted by the World Health Organization showed that 98% of those participants do not know ALS is and the tragic consequences of this

disease (Alvarado, 2014). This looks like 28 million people posting plain black squares on Instagram with the tag "#BlackoutTuesday" in June 2020 to raise awareness against racial injustice and police brutality despite never taking initiative to speak out or even educate themselves about the issue ever again (Ho, 2020). This looks like celebrating breast cancer awareness month in October every year by purchasing "pink products" from companies that claim to support breast cancer and wearing pink ribbons without understanding the various symptoms, methods of detection. Despite the diverse range of organizations, these campaigns all share something in common: the trend has overwritten the cause.

An emphasis on raising awareness itself is not the premise of this criticism. It is the fact that a lot of the "awareness" raised is not informational or substantial, but simply an acknowledgement of its existence. From KFC's pink fried chicken buckets for this campaign *Buckets for the Cure* in 2010 to Estee Lauder's *Pink Ribbon Collection* to "create a breast cancer-free world", the popularity of raising awareness for breast cancer paved way to the rise of 'pink-washing', the commercialization and exploitation of breast cancer (Lieber, 2018). A major criticism of pink-washing lies in the hypocrisy of these huge corporations: KFC's contribution to obesity and Estee Lauder's use of parabens and other toxic chemicals in their products were both proven to be correlated to breast cancer. In addition to this, other than the product itself, firms often do little to promote essential information about breast cancer such as risk factors and symptoms. Gayle Sulik, an award-winning medical sociologist at the University of Albany for her work in medical consumerism and breast cancer culture, argues that these awareness campaigns "trivialize breast cancer and limits our ability to comprehend what it's really like to face the disease" and the brutal "realities of risk, recurrence and treatment".

This misconception caused by the lack of information can be even more detrimental to movements that aim to change social perception through undeniable facts. During the height of the Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement, Feminista Jones, an author and activist known for her work in Black feminism, among other activists, claimed that the hashtag #BLM was oversaturated with black squares from all users which drowned posts with valuable information about the movement including video evidence of police brutality, stories of victims, where to donate and platforms to reach out to or speak out on.

However, this may be an inevitable trade-off for charities and movements. In a competitive society where various charities are desperately fighting for people's limited attention, time and money, it appears to be inevitable to resort to simple messages and aesthetic campaigns. User behavior only supports this. In the past 20 years, the average attention span has plummeted from 150 seconds to just 45 seconds, particularly because of the high exposure to phones, social media and other digital distractions (Nussenbaum, 2023). Therefore, charities commit to devising unique strategies to grab people's attention with something short and catchy which unfortunately compromises the quality and depth of the message. Eventually, what began as a well-intentioned campaign becomes extremely diluted because of how accessible it is.

Despite knowing the ineffectiveness of raising awareness in spreading real information, many organizations persist with the strategy because it is an easy, low-budget path for the organization to take while yielding incredible results. Even if it were unintentional, like the case of BLM, social media's in-built algorithms and people's herd behavior help create what is known as an 'information cascade', a term used to describe the phenomenon where information given to a few people is passed on to more and more people (Weverbergh & Vermoesen, n.d.). In the book "Six Degrees: The Science of a Connected Age", Duncan Watts, a computational social scientist

at the University of Pennsylvania, writes that these informational cascades are "self-perpetuating" and thus, unstoppable. As a result, "individuals in a population essentially stop behaving like individuals and start to act more like a coherent act."

From this perspective, the effortless success obtained through raising awareness makes it seem like the perfect tool, a means to an end. It is through awareness that the BLM movement saw more than 40% of counties in the US protest with nearly 95% of those counties having a white majority (Buchanan, Bui, & Patel, 2020). But success is measured in more than just participation and money. Within three years since the height of the movement following the murder of George Floyd, the portion of the population that support the BLM movement has decreased from 67% to 51% (Horowitz, Hurst, & Braga, 2023).

In many other cases, the long-term impact of raising awareness not only led to no action, but it was also counterproductive, leading to significant backlash or unintended consequences. The growing emphasis on mental health is a great example of this. Researchers at the University of Oxford proposed the "prevalence inflation hypothesis" which suggests that while health awareness campaigns have been able to improve recognition of mental health issues, they also caused overinterpretation and therefore an increase in the number of reported mental health problems (Foulkes & Andrews, 2023). This occurs when people interpret mild mood swings, sad days or everyday struggles to be significant mental health problems.

In 2006, the CDC introduced a national policy where, for school enrollment, adolescent girls need to be vaccinated against the human papilloma virus (HPV), a sexually transmitted infection that can lead to cervical cancer. Before this mandate, 90% of children received the vaccine, but in the following years, only 33% of girls and just 7% of boys were vaccinated. What led to this decline? Social conservatives perceived the mandate as encouraging sexual

promiscuity, and research suggests that individual tend to accept information about vaccine risk and benefits that align with their cultural and political beliefs. This resistance created a significant backlash, amplifying opposing views (Kahan, 2013).

In today's world, such a situation would likely be exacerbated by the influence of social media. Social media algorithms create echo chambers through personalized content feeds, tailoring what users see to reinforce their existing beliefs, feeding into confirmation biases. The platforms aim to maximize user engagement by showing content that aligns with their views --- posts and videos they replay, like or comment --- as well as content that contradicts their beliefs, prompting reactions like comments or shares out of frustration. This dynamic makes it far more difficult to se the broader context of a social issue.

Dan Kahan, a Yale University professor who researched the HPV program, suggests that the results could have been different with an alternative approach: instead of a high-profile lobbying campaign, a more conventional and gradual introduction through personal physicians could have been used to familiarize adolescents and their parents with the vaccine. This approach would have enabled a slower but more steady acceptance of the vaccine (Kahan, 2013).

Revisiting the case of the *ALS Ice Bucket Challenge*, on a micro-level the campaign was a huge success, and it made a difference for ALS patients and their loved ones. But on a macro-level, from a utilitarian standpoint, the success of the campaign needs to be reevaluated. ALS is a devastating disease that leads to paralysis with most patients living only two to five years after symptoms develop. But it is also incredibly rare with a 0.25% chance of developing this disease without a family history.

There are numerous examples like this where internet trends have clouded this logical evaluation. According to research conducted by Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) in 2011, the disease that causes the most death is heart disease that killed more than 596 thousand people. Yet, it only raised $54.1 million, less than four times less than breast cancer which raised more than $257 million while causing around 41 thousand deaths (Singal, 2014). Similarly, researchers at Northwestern University's Feinberg School of Medicine and Robert H. Lurie Comprehensive Cancer Center conducted a study to analyze the correlation between cancer research funding and annual deaths. As seen previously, breast cancer was significantly overfunded while other equally, or perhaps even more, deadly diseases such as lung cancer or colorectal cancer were severely underfunded. The study attributed the results to the stigma against certain cancers, such as the association of lung cancer with smoking or the discomfort of talking about reproductive organs reduces the funding for endometrial cancer (Kamath, Kircher, & Benson, 2019). Simply put, there is a misalignment between the amount of funds raised and the priority and urgency of the issue. Purely in terms of magnitude and scope of the impact, there are tons of other more urgent causes, or even more desperate diseases, so why do we donate to ALS or breast cancer?

It is apparent that the number of deaths is only one of the many metrics used to decide how to efficiently and effectively allocate resources to different diseases. Metrics such as the correlation between the disease and minority groups or if it is a newly discovered disease with little research and understanding of it should also be considered. But regardless, according to the UN World Food Program USA, most donate due to personal values and when donations come from raising awareness, they are subject to personal values and connections that do not reflect the needs of the society (World Food Program USA, 2023). This phenomenon is exacerbated

when this judgement made by the general public is dictated by a 30-second clip that prioritizes aesthetic and virality over tangible and significant information about the campaign. These metrics become even more complex when they cannot be quantified. Should we prioritize education or poverty? Criminal justice or reproductive justice? This social demographic or that social demographic?

Awareness, attention, money, time --- all of them matter to a social movement. Without raising awareness, more women would be unaware of early signs of breast cancer, more people would be ignorant of the racial injustices happening all around the US, more patients of ALS would have to suffer from the lack of treatment and equipment to support them. But once the organization is under the spotlight, it is imperative that they have a plan, a mission and a vision, something more than the simple act of raising awareness. Only through this can they take society one more step forward and bring about the necessary measures to achieve the change we want to see.

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